

# Construction and Architecture English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

**Audience: architects, construction managers, project engineers, site supervisors, estimators, owners' representatives, subcontractor coordinators, and design-build teams**

Focus: A construction and architecture English curriculum for design intent, RFIs, change orders, site coordination, safety, schedule pressure, permitting, punch lists, claims, and client communication.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

## Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

### Design Intent and Client Requirements

| Term             | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| design intent    | Working construction and architecture term used in design intent and client requirements; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| program          | Working construction and architecture term used in design intent and client requirements; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| constructability | Working construction and architecture term used in design intent and client requirements; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| scope            | Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.                                                                                                                     |

### Drawings, Specifications, and RFIs

| Term          | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| RFI           | Working construction and architecture term used in drawings, specifications, and rfis; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| specification | Working construction and architecture term used in drawings, specifications, and rfis; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| drawing set   | Working construction and architecture term used in drawings, specifications, and rfis; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| submittal     | Working construction and architecture term used in drawings, specifications, and rfis; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

### Change Orders and Cost Control

| Term         | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| change order | Working construction and architecture term used in change orders and cost control; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| allowance    | Working construction and architecture term used in change orders and cost control; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| contingency  | Working construction and architecture term used in change orders and cost control; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| notice       | Working construction and architecture term used in change orders and cost control; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

### Schedule, Sequencing, and Critical Path

| Term               | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| critical path      | Sequence of dependent work that determines the shortest feasible timeline.                                                                                                                                 |
| float              | Working construction and architecture term used in schedule, sequencing, and critical path; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| lookahead schedule | Working construction and architecture term used in schedule, sequencing, and critical path; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

| Term         | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| resequencing | Working construction and architecture term used in schedule, sequencing, and critical path; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

## Site Safety and Toolbox Talks

| Term            | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PPE             | Working construction and architecture term used in site safety and toolbox talks; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| fall protection | Working construction and architecture term used in site safety and toolbox talks; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| toolbox talk    | Working construction and architecture term used in site safety and toolbox talks; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| stop work       | Working construction and architecture term used in site safety and toolbox talks; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

## Permitting, Inspections, and Code Issues

| Term            | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| permit          | Working construction and architecture term used in permitting, inspections, and code issues; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| inspection      | Working construction and architecture term used in permitting, inspections, and code issues; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| code compliance | Working construction and architecture term used in permitting, inspections, and code issues; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| reinspection    | Working construction and architecture term used in permitting, inspections, and code issues; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

## Quality, Punch List, and Closeout

| Term                   | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| punch list             | Working construction and architecture term used in quality, punch list, and closeout; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| substantial completion | Working construction and architecture term used in quality, punch list, and closeout; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| warranty               | Working construction and architecture term used in quality, punch list, and closeout; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| closeout               | Working construction and architecture term used in quality, punch list, and closeout; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

## Claims, Disputes, and Documentation

| Term            | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| claim           | A statement that may need evidence, approval, qualification, or disclosure before it is used externally.                                                                                               |
| daily report    | Working construction and architecture term used in claims, disputes, and documentation; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |
| meeting minutes | Working construction and architecture term used in claims, disputes, and documentation; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

| Term        | Working meaning                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| entitlement | Working construction and architecture term used in claims, disputes, and documentation; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting. |

## Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

| Situation                                | Useful language                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Design Intent and Client Requirements    | Before we commit, I want to confirm design intent, program, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scope, fee, schedule, code, and constructability implications need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.                        |
| Drawings, Specifications, and RFIs       | Before we commit, I want to confirm RFI, specification, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If contract documents, rfi process, schedule impact, and design response are needed., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.                     |
| Change Orders and Cost Control           | Before we commit, I want to confirm change order, allowance, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If contract terms, notice, evidence, schedule, and pricing must be reviewed., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.                        |
| Schedule, Sequencing, and Critical Path  | Before we commit, I want to confirm critical path, float, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If critical path, float, resequencing, crew availability, and weather risk matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.                     |
| Site Safety and Toolbox Talks            | Before we commit, I want to confirm PPE, fall protection, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If safety requirements, stop-work authority, training, and documentation apply., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.                        |
| Permitting, Inspections, and Code Issues | Before we commit, I want to confirm permit, inspection, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If code interpretation, approved drawings, corrective work, and reinspection are required., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.               |
| Quality, Punch List, and Closeout        | Before we commit, I want to confirm punch list, substantial completion, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If life safety, substantial completion, warranties, and closeout documents need clarity., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step. |
| Claims, Disputes, and Documentation      | Before we commit, I want to confirm claim, daily report, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If daily reports, notices, photos, meeting minutes, and contract language matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.                       |

## High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.
- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

## Contrast Pairs

| Do not confuse         | Useful distinction                                                                                                                                                                   |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| design intent vs scope | In design intent and client requirements, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision. |
| RFI vs submittal       | In drawings, specifications, and rfis, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.    |

| Do not confuse                | Useful distinction                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| change order vs notice        | In change orders and cost control, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.           |
| critical path vs resequencing | In schedule, sequencing, and critical path, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.  |
| PPE vs stop work              | In site safety and toolbox talks, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.            |
| permit vs reinspection        | In permitting, inspections, and code issues, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision. |
| punch list vs closeout        | In quality, punch list, and closeout, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.        |
| claim vs entitlement          | In claims, disputes, and documentation, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.      |